ERA 4

Taxation & Resistance

1763 – 1775

British taxes · colonial protest · philosophical foundations

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did British taxation and Enlightenment ideas move colonists from protest toward revolution?

KEY TERMS

Stamp Act · Townshend Acts · Boston Massacre · Boston Tea Party · Sons of Liberty · Common Sense · natural rights

ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 3.3–3.4 · AMSCO Ch. 3.3–3.4

SECTION

No Taxation Without Representation

Two Views of Taxation

The British View

Parliament

- Colonists enjoy **virtual representation**—Parliament speaks for all Britons.
- Taxes are fair payment for defending the empire.
- Parliament holds authority over the colonies in all cases.

The Colonial View

The Colonists

- **No taxation without representation**—only our own assemblies may tax us.
- We elect no members to Parliament.
- These taxes threaten our liberties as Englishmen.

SECTION

Britain Taxes, Colonists Resist

A Decade of Escalation

1765
Stamp Act
First direct tax sparks colony-wide protest.

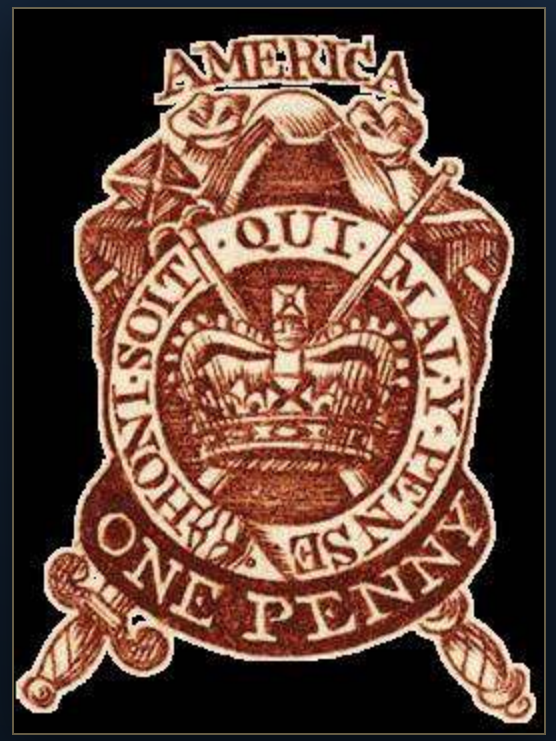
1767
Townshend Acts
New duties; met with boycotts.

1770
Boston Massacre
British troops kill five colonists.

1773
Tea Party
Sons of Liberty dump British tea.

1774
Intolerable Acts
Britain punishes Boston; colonies unite.

The Stamp Act, 1765



- Britain taxed printed materials—the first **direct tax** on the colonists.
- It hit every colony and every class, uniting opposition.
- The **Stamp Act Congress** was the first inter-colonial protest meeting.

Colonists Fight Back

- The **Sons and Daughters of Liberty** organized resistance.
- Colonists hanged tax collectors in effigy and boycotted British goods.
- The **boycott** proved the most effective weapon of all.



The Boston Massacre, 1770



- British troops fired into a Boston crowd, killing five.
- Among the dead was **Crispus Attucks**.
- Paul Revere's engraving turned it into powerful anti-British propaganda.

The Boston Tea Party, 1773

- The **Tea Act** gave Britain's **East India Company** a tea monopoly.
- The **Sons of Liberty** dumped three shiploads of tea into the harbor.
- It was a direct, defiant challenge to British authority.



The Intolerable Acts, 1774

Meant to isolate Massachusetts—instead the colonies united in the First Continental Congress

I

Boston Port Act

Closed Boston Harbor until the dumped tea was paid for.

II

Massachusetts Government Act

Stripped the colony of self-rule.

III

Quartering Act

Forced colonists to house British soldiers.

ENLIGHTENMENT IDEAS & COMMON SENSE

Philosophical Foundations

Ideas That Justified Revolution

I

Social Contract

John Locke: government exists by the people's consent.

II

Natural Rights

All people are born with rights to life, liberty, and property.

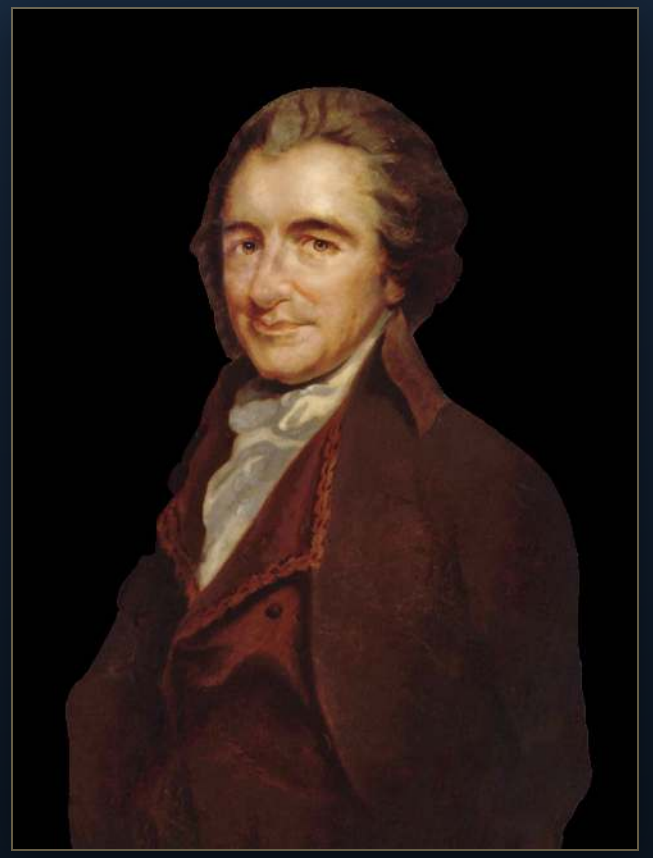
III

Right of Revolution

A government that violates those rights may justly be overthrown.

Paine's Common Sense, 1776

- **Thomas Paine**'s pamphlet made a blunt case for independence.
- Its plain, forceful language reached ordinary colonists.
- It became an instant bestseller and shifted public opinion decisively.



From Protest to Revolution

TAXES

New Duties

Britain taxes the colonies to pay its debts.

→

PROTEST

Resistance

Boycotts, congresses, and violence spread.

→

IDEAS

Enlightenment

Locke and Paine justify breaking away.

→

RESULT

Independence

Colonists move from resistance toward revolution.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Taxation & Resistance

1. Britain's taxes—**Sugar, Stamp, Townshend, and Tea Acts**—provoked escalating protest rooted in **"no taxation without representation."**

2. Colonists organized: the **Stamp Act Congress**, **Sons & Daughters of Liberty**, boycotts, the **Boston Massacre**, and the **Tea Party**—answered by the **Intolerable Acts**.

3. **Enlightenment ideas** and Paine's **Common Sense** turned resistance into a case for independence.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Taxation & Resistance

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **Enlightenment ideas** (Locke, social contract, natural rights) gave colonists a justification for resistance.

COMPARISON

Which act unified the colonies most — **Stamp, Townshend, or Intolerable**? Compare their effects.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

Place the **Boston Tea Party** in the wider context of a decade of imperial taxation and protest.

Up next — **Class 8: The American Revolution** (independence & the war)